



Golden leap: Carl Lewis soars to gold in the men's long jump final at the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics, sealing one of his four titles at the Games. GETTY IMAGES

Performance doesn't matter as much as winning. When the culture rewards you for being famous rather than being excellent, you start thinking, "Hey, I'm still winning medals — that's enough."

Are there any goals you wish you could have accomplished?

Of course! The long jump world record that Mike Powell holds. I never got that one. That's probably the only thing. I love Mike; we actually talk about it a lot. I have a lot of respect for him.

He was a great competitor and a great guy. We still see each other from time to time. The one thing he has over me is that record. And I'll say this — that day was the best jumping I ever did, and Mike beat me at the end of it. I can't say he got lucky or that I might have won on another day.

No, that was the best day I ever

had. I gave him my best shot, and he still won. I take pride in the fact that he had to break the world record just to beat me. And I don't think I'll see anyone break that record in my lifetime.

And thank God, Mike was so good that I don't think anyone ever will.

You're a coach now. (Lewis is the athletics coach at his alma mater, the University of Houston.) What's that like?

Last year, we had two athletes on our track team who won Olympic medals — a silver and a bronze. That's the happiest I've ever been because I know I helped them fulfil their lifetime goals.

It's probably interesting for you as a coach because you get to see that transformation in an athlete. Do you remember when you first realised, maybe at 12 or 13, that you weren't just fast but special?

Actually, it was a lot later — when I was 17. I was a late bloomer. When I was 13 or 14, I was just an average kid. At 17, I suddenly realised, Wow, I have a talent! That's when I had a

growth spurt.

I'd been running for years and had good technique, but I was small. I never thought I'd grow tall — and then suddenly I did. That made all the difference. Some kids develop really young; others much later. If you look at photos of me at 14 or 15, I look like a 12-year-old. Even at 16 or 17, I looked very young for my age.

Do you think it's possible to build a champion by doing the same things you did when you were young? Or would the process have to evolve completely?

There were great champions then and great champions now. The mindset is just different. Social media is different; the internet is different. It doesn't make things worse — just different.

But while some things change, the science doesn't. The ideal running mechanics are the same as they've been for hundreds of thousands of years. The best way to run hasn't changed. The problem now is that everyone wants to prove they're smarter than the past.

That's a big issue. There are very few checks and balances, especially in our sport. The internet is full of misinformation. When I go online, I see coaches and so-called experts talking — and at least ninety per cent of it is incorrect.

Everyone wants to be famous and promote themselves, not realising that the best coaches and the best programmes are usually promoted by others. If you're constantly promoting yourself, you're probably more focused on promotion than on actually doing the work.

You were one of the greatest as an athlete. How would you rate yourself as a coach?

I can't answer that — ratings have to come from someone else. But I was lucky because I had the greatest mentor. When I started as a volunteer, I went to coach (Tom) Tellez, and he guided me into coaching. I did a lot of studying. He gave me a stack of papers this high and told me to go read. So I read through everything, absorbed the